Frozen

By Bryony Lavery

NANCY: **(Pg 22-23)** *(in a school hall, to audience)* On April 17th, 1980, my daughter, Rhona walked out of my house to go to her Grandma's house. She never got there. She never came back. She was ten. She's been missing for five years. She will be fifteen years old tonight. I know she's alive, I have Faith. Every night I pray that whatever reason is stopping her coming home will be removed and that she'll phone or write or just knock on the door and say "Mum, it's me."

INTRODUCTION

*Frozen by Bryony Lavery is much more than a story of child abduction and murder. It is a story of the struggle to understand and to forgive when the very act of forgiveness seems absurd. Malcolm Gladwell once wrote: "The difference between a crime of evil and a crime of illness is the difference between a sin and a symptom . . ." **

An illness can be forgiven; but can someone who is inherently evil? And how do you determine the difference? In this selection Nancy, the mother of a murdered child and Agnetha, a psychologist, work through the struggle 20 years after Rhona disappears.

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NANCY: **(Pg 28-29)** Four days ago, two young policeman say . . . "We have apprehended a man in the unsuccessful attempted abduction of a young girl . . . subsequent inquiries have uncovered a lock-up shed. The earth floor contains the remains of other children. The man is now giving us names. One of them, he says, is Rhona." All this time I've been growing her up she's been -- He's had her buried away . . .

********* A large, academic hall *******

AGNETHA: **(Pg 34-35)** *(in "lecture mode – to audience)* "Serial Killing ... A Forgivable Act?" It is a critical examination of the differences between crimes of evil and crimes of illness. I base my critique upon a psychiatric and neurological study of the criminal brain. My name is Dr. Agnetha Gottmundsdottir. I am a ***psychiatric*** explorer. My chosen expedition -- the Arctic

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frozen sea that is . . . the criminal brain. *(Ralph's head lit as if it is an exhibit)* Let us take a look. *(walks over to stand behind Ralph, gesturing around his head, but not touching)*

The cortex is the thick covering of grey matter on the upper part of every human brain and the function of the cortex, in particular, the frontal lobes, is to modulate the impulses that surge up from within the brain. To provide judgement, to learn and stick to rules of everyday life. They are responsible for making us human.

Ralph Ian Wantage is currently in Long Larron Maximum Security Prison serving a life sentence for the abduction, sexual assault and murder of 7 young girls over a period of 21 years.

******** Agnetha and Ralph, prison cell*******

AGNETHA: (Pg 37) I'm not gonna harm you. I'm gonna tap you on the nose . . . *(She the bridge of his nose.*

RALPH: *(blinks rapidly, distressed)* Hey, hey, hey, hey . . .

AGNETHA: *(moves away, showing us on her own nose)* When you tap someone on the bridge of the nose, it's reasonable for the person to blink a coupla times because there is a threat from outside. When it's clear there is no threat, a person should be able to accommodate that. But if the subject blinks more than three times, that's what we call "insufficiency of suppression" which may show frontal lobe disfunction. You can't adapt to a new situation. There's a certain rigidity there. Like the person is ice-bound

********* *Nancy's house*********

NANCY: (Pg 38) You can go and be there when they die . . . murderers. They show you the electric chair, how it all works. And then, you can be present, members of the victims' families at that final moment. **(Pg 37)** I'd like to see him die. Watch him suffer. He wouldn't suffer like she suffered. But it would be something. An eye for an eye.

********* A large, academic hall *******

AGNETHA: (Pg 46) *(in "lecture" mode – to audience)* Over the years Dr. Nabkus and myself have studied more than 250 dangerous criminals. In significant numbers, these men have incurred physical damage to the brain. After Dr. Nabkus has finished his medical history, I

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look for evidence of child abuse **(Pg 50)** [It] causes profound and pathological changes in the structure of the brain as surely as does physical injury. We brain scanned the children of severe neglect [and] found that entire structures of their cortex never properly developed. **(Pg 51-52)** What you get is a kind of erraticness -- they can be very different in one situation compared to another. There is a sense that they don't have a larger moral compass.

******* Ralph and Agnetha, prison cell*******

AGNETHA: (Pg 62) No remorse then, Ralphie?

RALPH: Remorse. So what is that . . . remorse?

AGNETHA: Like Regret. But more. You repent your sin. You feel sorrow, pity, compassion. A sort of . . . ***tender*** feeling.

RALPH: I can't say I do. *(pause, thinks)* The only thing I'm sorry about is that it's not legal

AGNETHA: What's not legal?

RALPH: Killing girls.

******** Nancy meets with Agnetha *******

NANCY: (Pg 59-61) I'm "in a very bad space." I know that. I know I'm ready.

AGNETHA: How?

NANCY: He . . . *(she has to do this)* forced her into the van. And, and, and he. . . wrapped her in polythene sheeting. She was unconscious but she wasn't dead then. He took her to a ***shed*** and we think he sexually assaulted her before he held the polythene on her face and suffocated her. *(short of breath)*

AGNETHA: Breathe. *(both inhale and exhale; Nancy following Agnetha)*

NANCY: I'm accepting she's dead. But *(pause. somehow an awful admission of guilt)* I'm not! And I need to *(hand gesture of moving forward)* So he's the next step. I want to know ***why***. I want to know why ***her***. She's 10! I want him to know what he's done. I want him to know how I ***feel***. I want to ***understand***. If I could understand **why** . . . I might be able to *(hand gesture of moving forward)* They said you could help. It's time -- I want a visit.

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The following are separate monologues from Agnetha and Nancy interspersed – they are not talking to one another.

AGNETHA: (Pg 67) *(calm, clinical)* Most forensic psychiatrists tend to buy into the notion of evil. I don't. I can't. I find no evidence that people are born evil. To be evil is to be "morally depraved." That bespeaks having conscious control over something. The serial murders I have tested are not in that category. Their deeds themselves are bizarre, grotesque, life-destroying -- but not evil. They are driven by forces beyond their control.

NANCY: (Pg 65) *(angry)* I'd swing that bloody American doctor woman round by her. . . *(quotes)* **"**The ***experiment*** is unviable! The components unstable!" Who does she think she is? I've written some letters made some phone calls. I'll get that visit!

AGNETHA: (Pg 67) *(calm, clinical)* The difference between a crime of evil and a crime of illness is the difference between a sin and a symptom.

NANCY: (Pg 55-56) *(incensed)* If I go to see him, I'm taking a gun. Blow his brains all over the wall. I'm taking a knife; slice his thing off. Stick the blade through his eye and take out his brains! What he thought to do -- what he did . . . She was my little girl! And she said *(pause)* forgive that monster. I can't do that. How can I do that? It's too much. *(long pause as she battles with her emotions)*

AGNETHA: (Pg 67-68) *(somewhat judgy)* I guess as a ***moral*** society -- as a ***punishment*** society . . . We can't let the notion of these deeds being "symptoms" intrude in the relationship between murderers and the rest of us.

NANCY: (Pg 39) *(deep breath)* I can forgive. But I can't forget.

*******Prison visiting room -- Nancy enters*******

NANCY: (Pg 68-73) *(to guard)* That's him? *(goes to stand in front of Ralph)* Ralph Wantage? *(he looks up; barely nods)* Nancy Shirley. You got my letter. You agreed to see me.

RALPH: She was your kid . . . one of them.

NANCY: Rhona **RALPH:** Rhona. *(pause)*

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NANCY: I want you to know I forgive you for killing my daughter. *(silence -- Ralph abruptly covers his eyes with both hands)* I don't hate you. I used to, but I don't anymore. *(silence, Ralph has nothing to say)* I've brought some photographs, would you like to see them?

RALPH: Of . . . her?

NANCY: Rhona *(she gets them out. A small dog-eared selection, hands them to him in turn)* As a baby. *(next)* That's me holding her. Her cat is Fluff. *(next)* This is Rhona dressed as an octopus for a fancy-dress competition.

RALPH: Did she win?

NANCY: She came third behind Little Miss Muffet and a Loch Ness Monster.

RALPH: She should have won. *(beat)* I don't think I hurt her . . .

NANCY: You did.

RALPH: I don't think she was frightened at all . . .

NANCY: She must have been. She must have been frightened! *(Ralph thinks . . . Nancy watches him carefully. When he looks up suddenly, she holds his gaze. He looks away . . . she touches his arm)* Your dad? What did he do?

RALPH: My dad, well, he was the disciplinarian obviously.

NANCY: Made you behave, did he?

RALPH: Oh, yes! Say you swore filthy language . . . He's got you by the hair here *(back of neck)* And you're in the washing up water. Wash your mouth out with soap water! Or you done wrong . . . anything . . . he's *(in Dad's voice)* "See it in my eyes? Can you see it, you little pillock? I'm looking into you and I'm seeing shit! You keep yourself clean! You hear me? *(sound of a thump on flesh . . . Ralph registers it, side of head)* You deaf little bugger! *(another thump, same side of head)* You listening to me? *(tap on forehead)* You sand still and don't move one muscle! Not one! You don't even blink until you know I mean what I say. See it in my eyes?" *(blinking rapidly)*

NANCY: Frightening bugger. *(Ralph nods)* Hurt you a lot. *(beat, then another nod)* Can you see it hurt Rhona then? Can you see it frightened her? What you did.

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RALPH: *(Ralph thinks impassive for a long time, then)* Yes. *(nods, tears in his eyes . . . he wipes them fiercely. Violently. Dry painful sobs start. Nancy watches. He holds his chest in pain as the sobs subside. Calmly Nancy takes out a tissue and hands it to him) (harshly)* Don't come and bother me again. *(Nancy exits)*

******* Agnetha and Ralph – Prison cell*********

AGNETHA: **(Pg 76-78)** Well, Ralph. This is my last visit. I wondered if you wanted to tell me anything more. And I came to say "Goodbye."

RALPH: *(cautiously)* I've been wanting to tell you things. I think I caught cancer or something. *(motions to his chest)* Here. That's lungs right? Lung cancer.

AGNETHA: What does the doctor say?

RALPH: Says it's just stress! Stress is in here *(motions to his forehead)* I know where stress is! This ***gnawing***, here! *(motions to his chest)* Not stress!

AGNETHA: That's your heart, Ralph. How long have you been in pain?

RALPH: It started . . . night after that mother of that girl Rhona I done came . . . That was Thursday . . . so *(Counts on his fingers)* It's been a bit.

AGNETHA: Mrs. Shirley came to see you? I recommended she . . .

RALPH: Well, you were overruled by the Doctor-in-Charge!

AGNETHA: And she visited with you?

RALPH: She's forgive me, actually. *(spasm in his chest)*

AGNETHA: *(thoughtfully)* What you are feeling may be psychological. What you are feeling may be remorse and that will be very painful for you, Ralph.

RALPH: *(hardens again, he speaks to himself)* It's a question of finding a window of opportunity

******* Ralph, alone in his cell********

RALPH: **(Pg 79)** *(Ralph, in his cell, sweating. Fashioning a noose with his belt and a long cloth. He slings it over the pull up bar and stands on his chair)* Gnawed to death? I don't think so. *(completes his preparations. Kicks the chair away from him. He hangs, choking, jerking)*

******* Graveside – Ralph's funeral********

(Nancy stands at the gravesite. Athena, entering, watches her for a few seconds)

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AGNETHA: **(Pg 79-82)** Not a big funeral . . .

NANCY: *(sarcastically)* Bit of a surprise . . . person with his talent for putting sunshine in everybody's life.

AGNETHA: You went to see him.

NANCY: And you tried to stop me.

AGNETHA: I was trying to protect everybody

NANCY: Him. **AGNETHA:** Everybody

NANCY: Him. How much time and energy did you give him? And me? *(beat)* You look upset. Were you fond of *(beat)* Ralph?

AGNETHA: It's not for Ralph . . . It's for somebody else. For me.

NANCY: Me as well. I couldn't feel much for him really . . .

AGNETHA: No. It was . . . not easy. *(Both nod thoughtfully)*

NANCY: Do you think he did it . . . the . . . suicide . . . because I went to see him?

AGNETHA: *(long silence)* Yes. *(long silence, then in a rare show of emotion)* My colleague and best friend, David, died three months ago. Stupid accident – wearing a seat belt, observing the speed limit. A truck goes out of control – smashes the care. The truck driver is unhurt. David – I worked with him every day for 10 years. Two days before he died I slept with him. It just happened. His wife is a very good friend. Why am I telling you this?

NANCY: Why are you?

AGNETHA: Do I tell her?

NANCY: No. You just suffer. "The difference between a crime of evil and a crime of illness is the difference between a sin and a symptom . . ." ***Your*** words. I read your thesis. You knew what you were doing. Live with it.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier – MS
NIETOC
IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
NJ State Finalist

****Introduction Quote by Malcolm Gladwell***
Malcolm Gladwell (2009). "What the Dog Saw: And Other Adventures", p.140, Hachette UK

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